

WORLD WAR ERA MEDALS

The World Wars saw countless acts of individual gallantry amid the mass actions of huge armies. Medals continued to be awarded for acts of exceptional bravery, and the sheer numbers of combatants meant that more were issued than ever before. Some medals that had been introduced previously took on a new significance during this period – notably Germany's "Blue Max" and the USA's Purple Heart.



▲ MILITARY CROSS

Date 1914

Origin UK

Instituted in 1914 as a gallantry award for British army officers of a lower precedence than the Victoria Cross (see p.258) and the Distinguished Service Order, from 1993 onwards, the Military Cross has been open to all ranks for gallantry in land operations.

► IRON CROSS

Date 1914

Origin Germany

The Iron Cross was issued to all ranks, but only those who had already received a 2nd Class award could receive the 1st Class version. In World War I, around 4 million 2nd Class and 145,000 1st Class medals were awarded. The medal shown is a 1939 design with a central swastika.



▲ OTTOMAN WAR MEDAL

Date 1915

Origin Turkey

Conflict World War I

Better known as the Gallipoli Star, this decoration was awarded for the duration of World War I to Turkish soldiers and their allies for gallantry in battle.



◀ WORLD WAR I VICTORY MEDAL

Date 1919

Origin US

The Victory Medal, as it was first known, was issued to US forces who had served in World War I and actions in Russia (1919–20).

► CROIX DE GUERRE

Date 1915

Origin France

This medal was issued to individuals for bravery or other military virtues displayed on the battlefield during World War I, World War II, and in other campaigns not fought on French soil. The example pictured is a World War II medal.

Bronze Maltese cross with swords between the arms



Golden eagles between the arms of the cross



► POUR LE MÉRITE (BLUE MAX)

Date 1740–1918

Origin Germany

This order was both a civilian and military honour until 1810, when it was restricted to serving military personnel. One of the first airmen to receive the award was World War I flying ace Max Immelmann; his fame led to the order becoming known as the Blue Max.



▲ MEMORIAL PLAQUE

Date 1919

Origin UK

Conflict World War I

Awarded to the next-of-kin of those who lost their lives as a result of active service in World War I, this 120mm (4¾in) diameter bronze plaque bears the name of the dead serviceman.

► ORDER OF THE PATRIOTIC WAR

Date 1942

Origin Soviet Union

Conflict World War II

This silver-and-enamel medal was awarded to Soviet military personnel who fought on the Eastern Front, and to partisan fighters for personal bravery. The Order of the 1st Class was issued 344,000 times, while 1,028,000 2nd Class awards were made.

